



Syria



Stretching from the eastern Mediterranean to the Tigris River, Syria's borders are regarded as an artificial creation of French colonial rule by many Syrians. Foreign relations are turbulent.



GEOGRAPHY

A short stretch of coastal plain is backed by a low range of hills. The Euphrates River cuts through a vast interior desert plateau.



CLIMATE

Mediterranean coastal climate. Inland areas are arid. In winter, snow is common on the mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Syrians live within 60 miles (100 km) of the coast. 90% are Muslim, including the politically dominant Shi'a Alawis. In the north and west are groups of Kurds, Armenians, and Turkic-speaking peoples. Some 460,000 Palestinian refugees live in Syria, and over a million Iraqis have fled here since 2003. There is a growing gulf between rich and poor. Human rights are an issue, but women's rights are among the best in the Arab world.



THE ECONOMY

Oil, though production is falling. Natural gas. High defense spending. Large public sector. Agriculture: fruit, cotton, and grain. Under US sanctions.



INSIGHT: *Syria is an ancient land; there are at least 3500 as yet unexcavated archaeological sites*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Syrian Arab Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1941

CAPITAL: Damascus

POPULATION: 21.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 71,498 sq. miles
(184,180 sq. km)

DENSITY: 308 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, French, Kurdish, Armenian, Circassian, Assyrian, other
RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 74%, other Muslim 16%, Christian 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 89%, Kurd 6%, other 3%, Armenian, Turkmen, Circassian 2%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Syrian pound = 100 piastres